

04

The c3-d3 Spanish System

A universal White setup, restrained centers, and the moment to change from maneuvering to action.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will use c3-d3 as a learning platform without turning it into an automatic move sequence.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate candidates for the side to move, identify the opponent's strongest resource, and choose the resulting structure you can explain. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 019 | PAGE 4

Decode: The compact c3-d3 shell*A quiet center buys maneuvering time but gives the opponent central freedom.*

LESSON 020 | PAGE 8

Play: The compact c3-d3 shell*A quiet center buys maneuvering time but gives the opponent central freedom.*

LESSON 021 | PAGE 12

Decode: Knight route d2-f1-g3*A reroute is justified by the job at the destination, not by tradition.*

LESSON 022 | PAGE 16

Play: Knight route d2-f1-g3*A reroute is justified by the job at the destination, not by tradition.*

LESSON 023 | PAGE 20

Decode: Choosing the d4 break*Break only when your pieces improve after the pawn exchanges.*

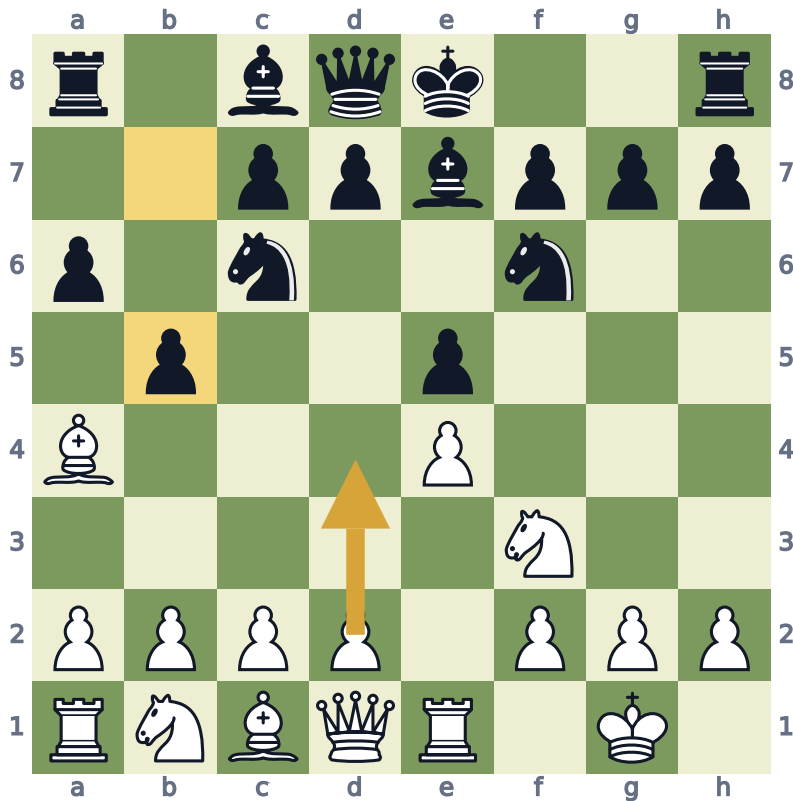
LESSON 024 | PAGE 24

Play: Choosing the d4 break*Break only when your pieces improve after the pawn exchanges.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will use c3-d3 as a learning platform without turning it into an automatic move sequence.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The compact c3-d3 shell



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

d3 keeps e4 secure and delays central clarification, giving White time for Nbd2-f1-g3 and flexible kingside play.

DECISION RULE

What did d3 concede in central space, and which maneuver compensates for it?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black gains room for ...Na5, ...c5, or ...d5 and should use the extra time to challenge White's compact center.

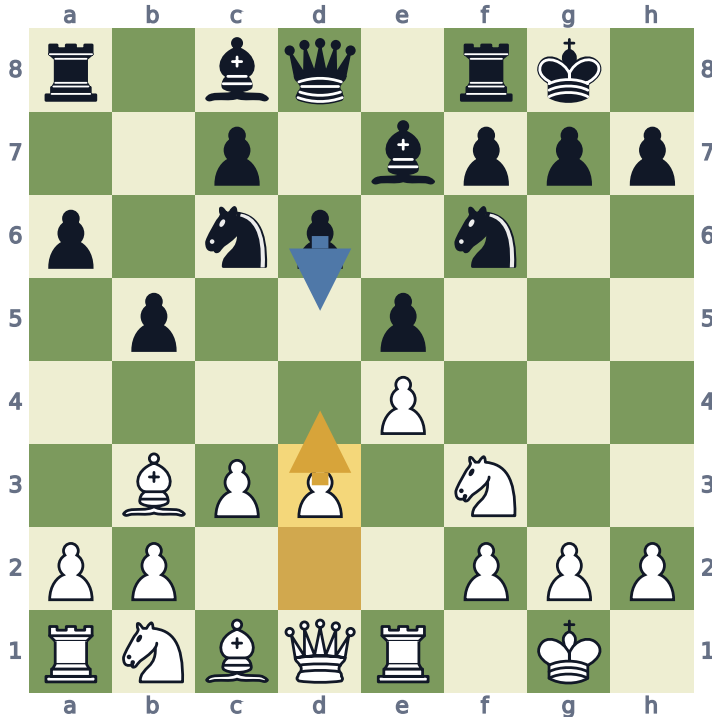
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White improves pieces, plays h3, Nbd2-f1-g3, and chooses d4 only when it wins a favorable transformation.

MEMORY RULE | A quiet center buys maneuvering time but gives the opponent central freedom.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

d3 keeps e4 secure and delays central clarification, giving White time for Nbd2-f1-g3 and flexible kingside play.

BLACK'S PLAN

Black gains room for ...Na5, ...c5, or ...d5 and should use the extra time to challenge White's compact center.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S PLAN

White improves pieces, plays h3, Nbd2-f1-g3, and chooses d4 only when it wins a favorable transformation.

FAILURE MODE

Playing the universal setup without noticing Black has achieved ...d5 in one move.

DECISION TEST

Ask: What did d3 concede in central space, and which maneuver compensates for it? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

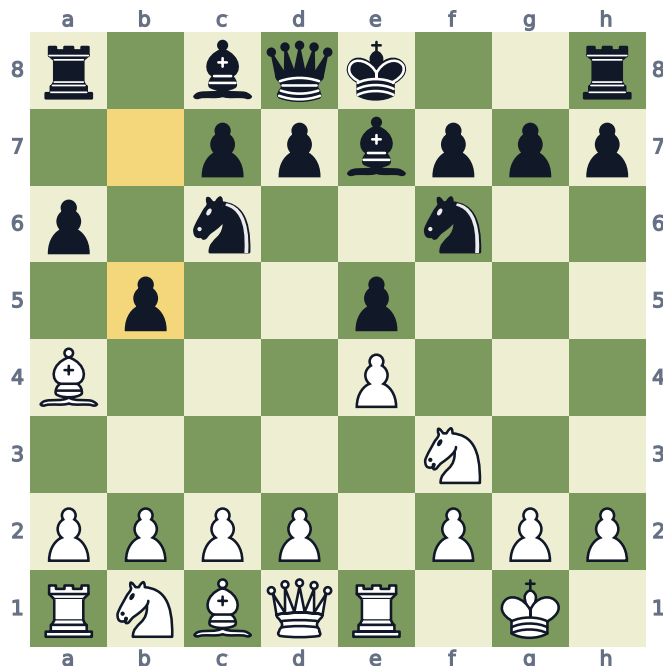
RULE | A quiet center buys maneuvering time but gives the opponent central freedom.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. d3



- Ba4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

d3 keeps e4 secure and delays central clarification, giving White time for Nbd2-f1-g3 and flexible kingside play.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

What did d3 concede in central space, and which maneuver compensates for it? White's resource is: White improves pieces, plays h3, Nbd2-f1-g3, and chooses d4 only when it wins a favorable transformation. The line fails as a template when: Playing the universal setup without noticing Black has achieved ...d5 in one move.

STORE THIS | A quiet center buys maneuvering time but gives the opponent central freedom.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

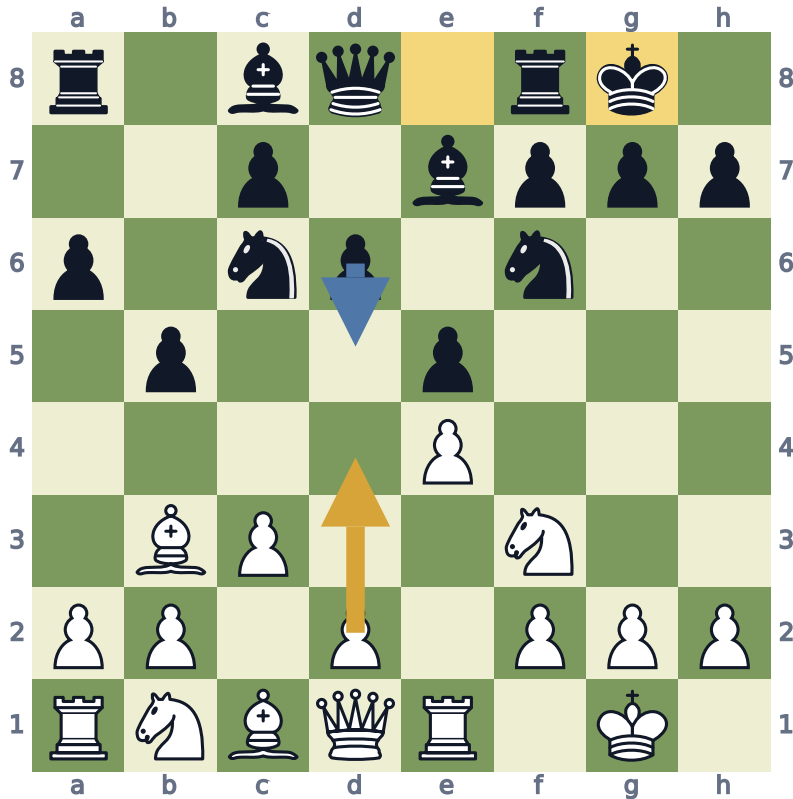
1. d3 keeps e4 secure and delays central clarification, giving White time for Nbd2-f1-g3 and flexible kingside play. 2. Black gains room for ...Na5, ...c5, or ...d5 and should use the extra time to challenge White's compact center. 3. White improves pieces, plays h3, Nbd2-f1-g3, and chooses d4 only when it wins a favorable transformation. 4. What did d3 concede in central space, and which maneuver compensates for it? 5. Playing the universal setup without noticing Black has achieved ...d5 in one move.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The compact c3-d3 shell



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

d3 keeps e4 secure and delays central clarification, giving White time for Nbd2-f1-g3 and flexible kingside play.

DECISION RULE

What did d3 concede in central space, and which maneuver compensates for it?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

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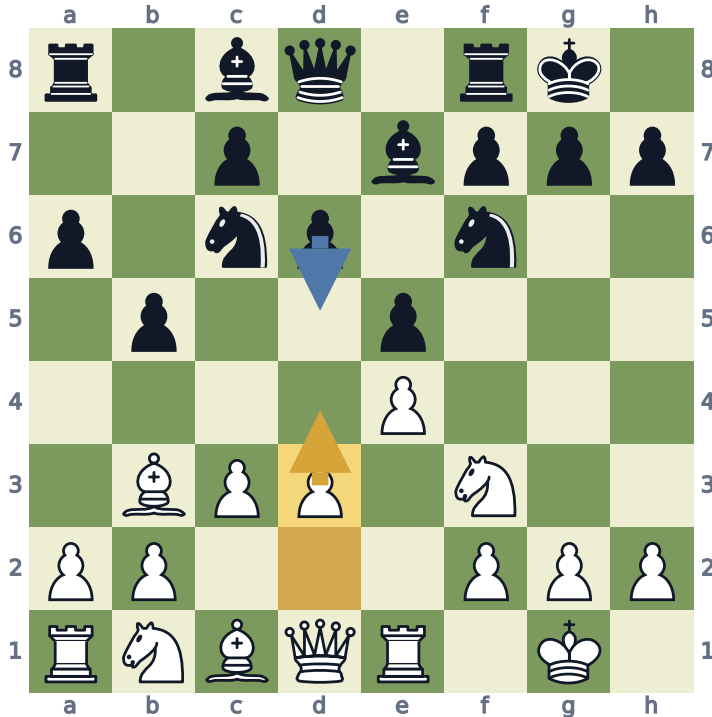
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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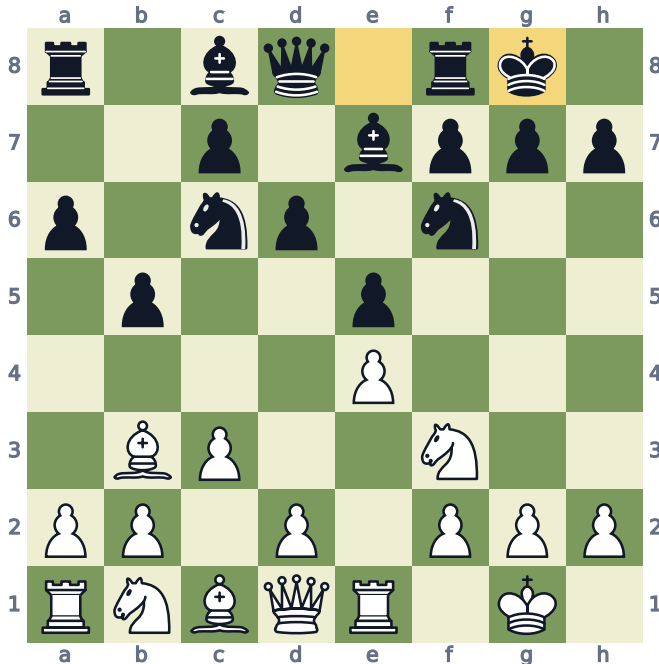
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

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1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. d3



- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.
- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- c3: White supports d4 and reserves c2 as a retreat square for the Spanish bishop.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.

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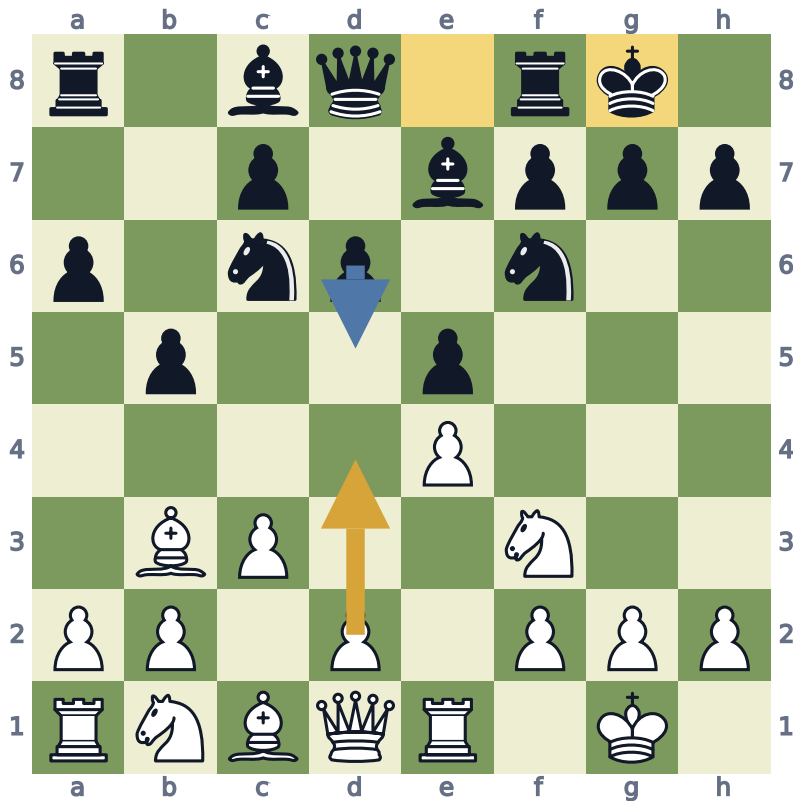
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Knight route d2-f1-g3



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The b1 knight often reaches g3 through d2 and f1, supporting f5, h5, and central squares without blocking the c-pawn.

DECISION RULE

Is g3 the knight's real destination, and what useful action can Black take during the journey?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black uses the maneuvering time for ...c5, ...Re8, and pressure that limits the knight's destination.

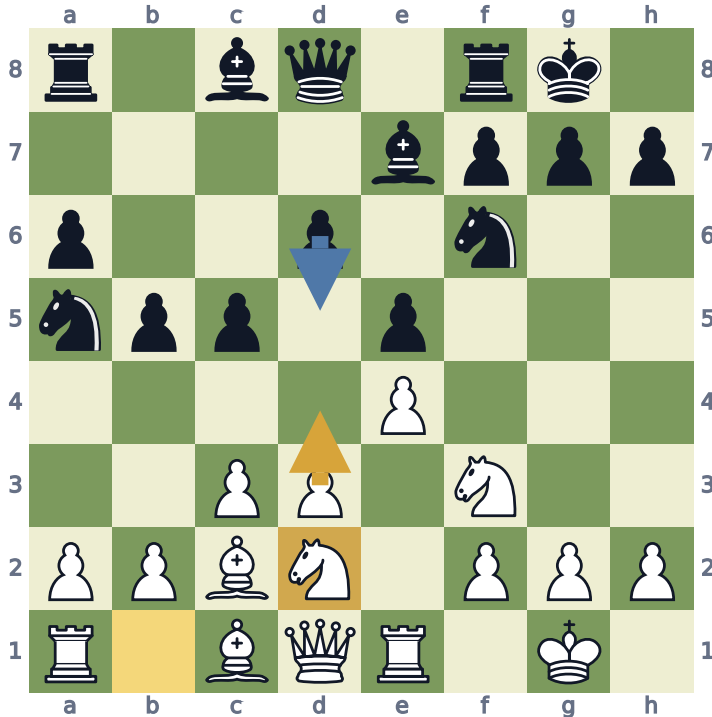
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White accepts several tempi because the final g3 knight coordinates an attack and frees other pieces.

MEMORY RULE | A reroute is justified by the job at the destination, not by tradition.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The b1 knight often reaches g3 through d2 and f1, supporting f5, h5, and central squares without blocking the c-pawn.

BLACK'S PLAN

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S PLAN

White accepts several tempi because the final g3 knight coordinates an attack and frees other pieces.

FAILURE MODE

Following the route when f1 or g3 is tactically unavailable or strategically irrelevant.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Is g3 the knight's real destination, and what useful action can Black take during the journey? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

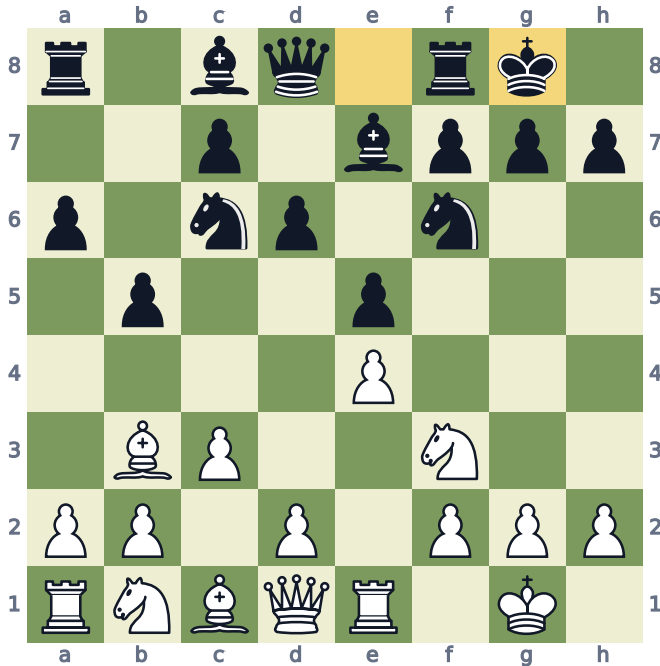
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Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.
- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
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WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The b1 knight often reaches g3 through d2 and f1, supporting f5, h5, and central squares without blocking the c-pawn.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Is g3 the knight's real destination, and what useful action can Black take during the journey? White's resource is: White accepts several tempi because the final g3 knight coordinates an attack and frees other pieces. The line fails as a template when: Following the route when f1 or g3 is tactically unavailable or strategically irrelevant.

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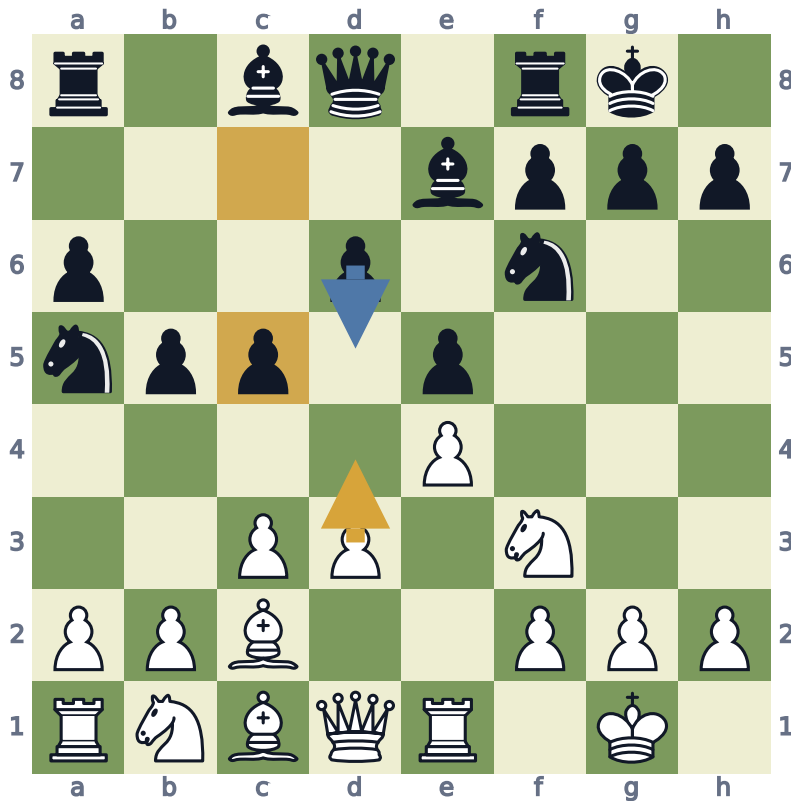
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Knight route d2-f1-g3



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DECISION RULE

Is g3 the knight's real destination, and what useful action can Black take during the journey?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

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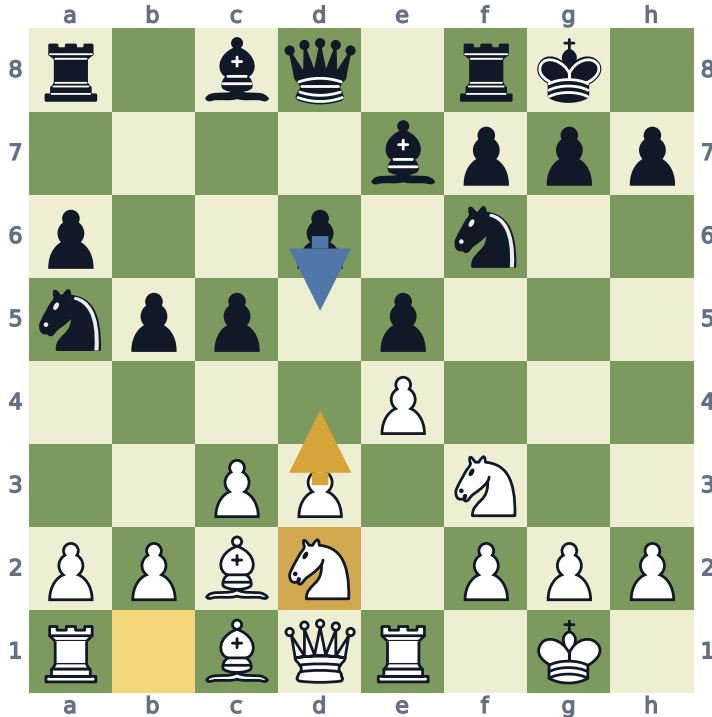
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The plan map



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BLACK'S PLAN

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S PLAN

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FAILURE MODE

Following the route when f1 or g3 is tactically unavailable or strategically irrelevant.

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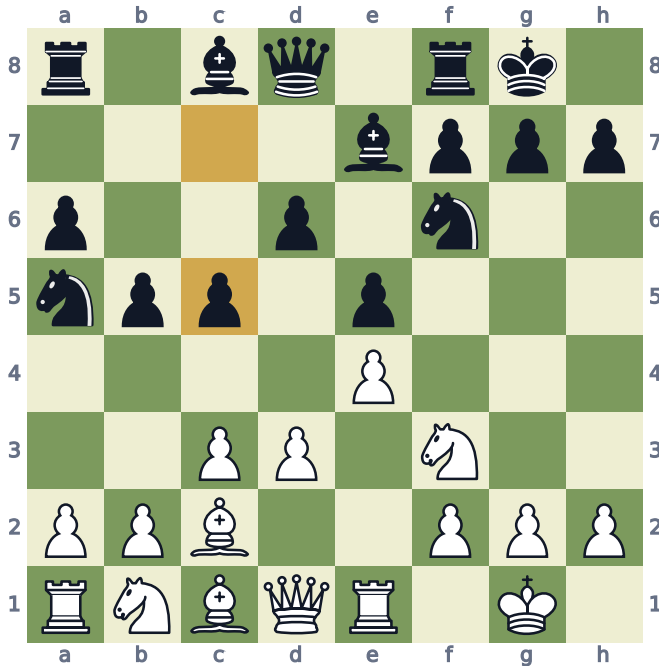
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- c3: White supports d4 and reserves c2 as a retreat square for the Spanish bishop.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- d3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Na5: Black reroutes a knight to a5; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Bc2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- c5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The b1 knight often reaches g3 through d2 and f1, supporting f5, h5, and central squares without blocking the c-pawn.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Is g3 the knight's real destination, and what useful action can Black take during the journey? White's resource is: White accepts several tempi because the final g3 knight coordinates an attack and frees other pieces. The line fails as a template when: Following the route when f1 or g3 is tactically unavailable or strategically irrelevant.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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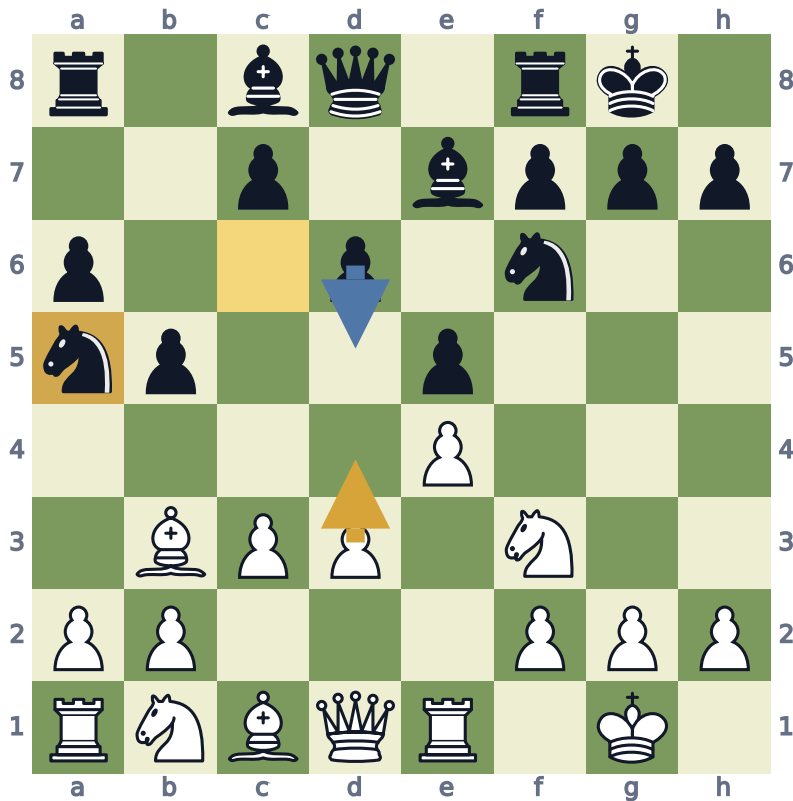
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 20 plies from memory, then replay: 8. c3 O-O 9. d3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Choosing the d4 break



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White waits until pieces support d4 and Black's pieces have declared themselves, then challenges e5 with maximum coordination.

DECISION RULE

After d4, which recapture preserves the better center and which file opens for each rook?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black decides whether to maintain tension, exchange, or counter with ...d5 based on piece placement.

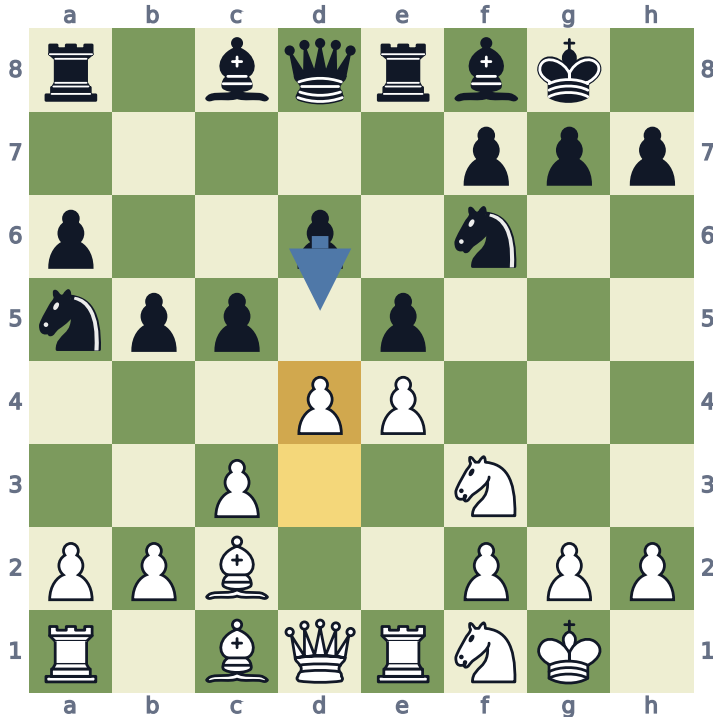
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White opens lines for bishops and rooks while preventing Black from gaining a free central break.

MEMORY RULE | Break only when your pieces improve after the pawn exchanges.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK'S PLAN

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S PLAN

White opens lines for bishops and rooks while preventing Black from gaining a free central break.

FAILURE MODE

Playing d4 by schedule when the pieces are not ready for the resulting open center.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After d4, which recapture preserves the better center and which file opens for each rook? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

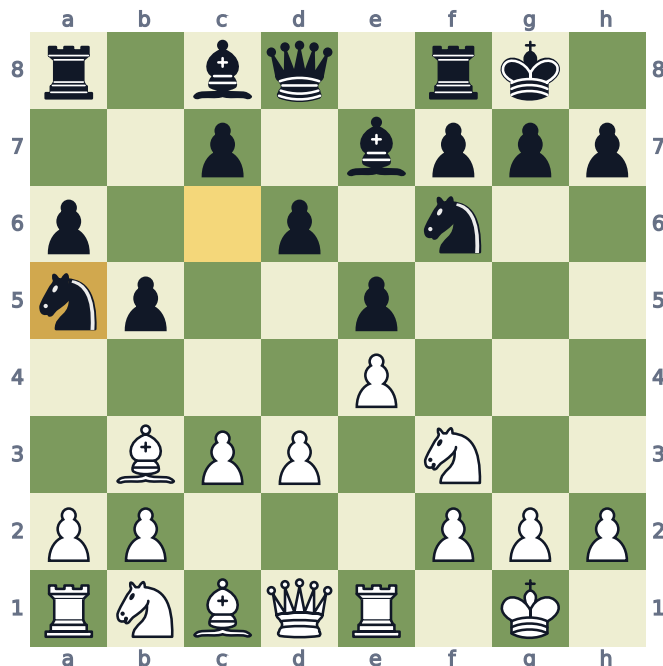
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- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
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After d4, which recapture preserves the better center and which file opens for each rook? White's resource is: White opens lines for bishops and rooks while preventing Black from gaining a free central break. The line fails as a template when: Playing d4 by schedule when the pieces are not ready for the resulting open center.

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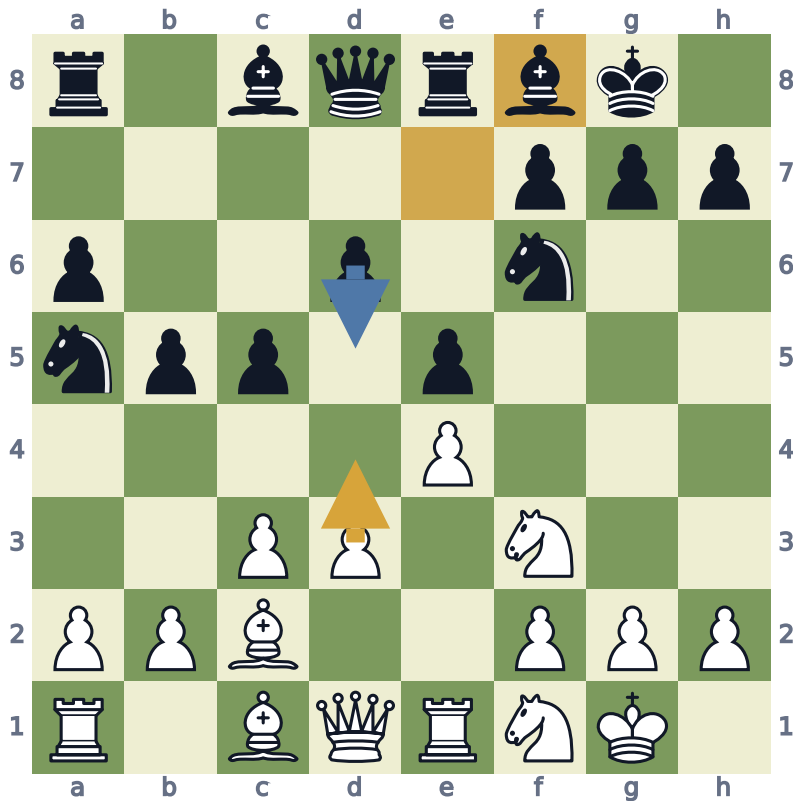
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. d3 Na5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Choosing the d4 break



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White waits until pieces support d4 and Black's pieces have declared themselves, then challenges e5 with maximum coordination.

DECISION RULE

After d4, which recapture preserves the better center and which file opens for each rook?

SIDE TO MOVE

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BLACK'S RESOURCES

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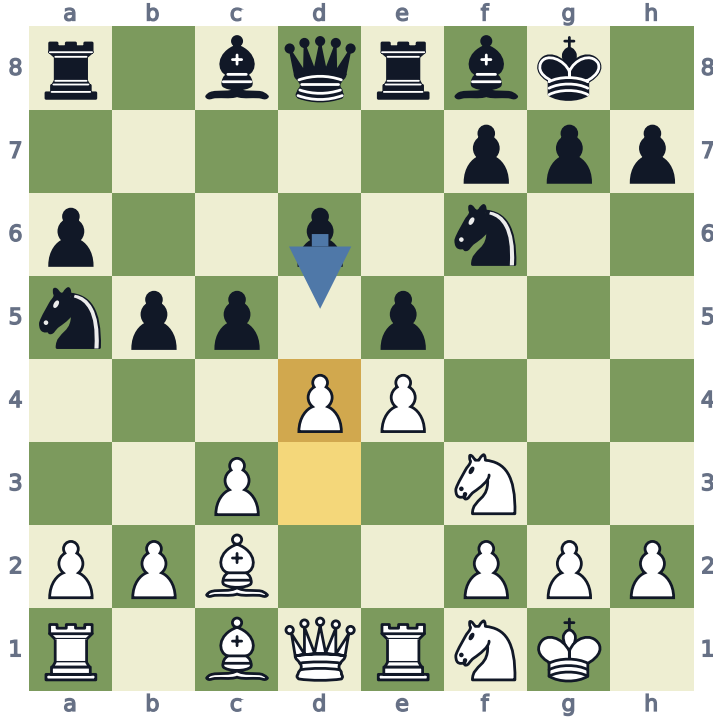
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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S PLAN

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FAILURE MODE

Playing d4 by schedule when the pieces are not ready for the resulting open center.

DECISION TEST

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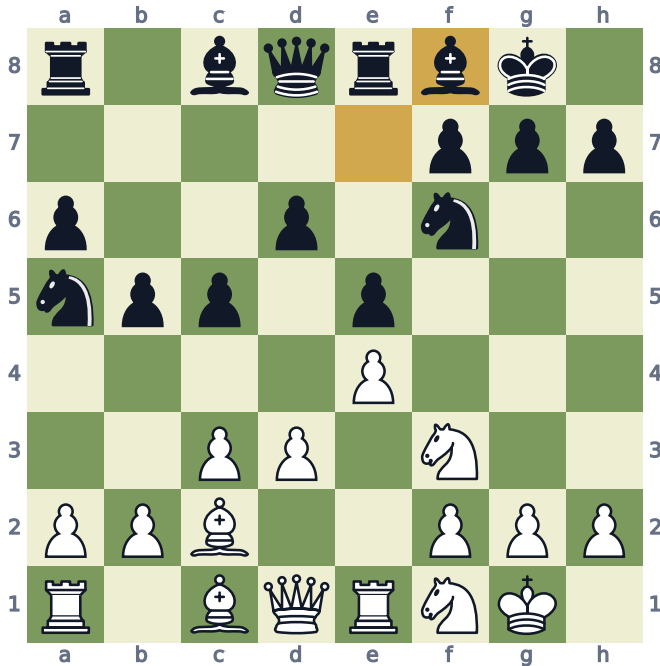
RULE | Break only when your pieces improve after the pawn exchanges.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. d3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. Nbd2 Re8 12. Nf1 Bf8 13. d4



- Bc2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- c5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Re8: Black places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- Nf1: White reroutes a knight to f1; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Bf8: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White waits until pieces support d4 and Black's pieces have declared themselves, then challenges e5 with maximum coordination.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After d4, which recapture preserves the better center and which file opens for each rook? White's resource is: White opens lines for bishops and rooks while preventing Black from gaining a free central break. The line fails as a template when: Playing d4 by schedule when the pieces are not ready for the resulting open center.

STORE THIS | Break only when your pieces improve after the pawn exchanges.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. White waits until pieces support d4 and Black's pieces have declared themselves, then challenges e5 with maximum coordination. 2. Black decides whether to maintain tension, exchange, or counter with ...d5 based on piece placement. 3. White opens lines for bishops and rooks while preventing Black from gaining a free central break. 4. After d4, which recapture preserves the better center and which file opens for each rook? 5. Playing d4 by schedule when the pieces are not ready for the resulting open center.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 24 plies from memory, then replay: 10. Bc2 c5 11. Nbd2 Re8 12. Nf1 Bf8

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 019 Decode: The compact c3-d3 shell

Prompt: What did d3 concede in central space, and which maneuver compensates for it?

Recall: A quiet center buys maneuvering time but gives the opponent central freedom.

LESSON 020 Play: The compact c3-d3 shell

Prompt: What did d3 concede in central space, and which maneuver compensates for it?

Recall: A quiet center buys maneuvering time but gives the opponent central freedom.

LESSON 021 Decode: Knight route d2-f1-g3

Prompt: Is g3 the knight's real destination, and what useful action can Black take during the journey?

Recall: A reroute is justified by the job at the destination, not by tradition.

LESSON 022 Play: Knight route d2-f1-g3

Prompt: Is g3 the knight's real destination, and what useful action can Black take during the journey?

Recall: A reroute is justified by the job at the destination, not by tradition.

LESSON 023 Decode: Choosing the d4 break

Prompt: After d4, which recapture preserves the better center and which file opens for each rook?

Recall: Break only when your pieces improve after the pawn exchanges.

LESSON 024 Play: Choosing the d4 break

Prompt: After d4, which recapture preserves the better center and which file opens for each rook?

Recall: Break only when your pieces improve after the pawn exchanges.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's plan, one candidate for the side to move, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

The compact c3-d3 shell

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. d3

Decision: What did d3 concede in central space, and which maneuver compensates for it?

Memory: A quiet center buys maneuvering time but gives the opponent central freedom.

CARD 2

Knight route d2-f1-g3

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. d3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. Nbd2

Decision: Is g3 the knight's real destination, and what useful action can Black take during the journey?

Memory: A reroute is justified by the job at the destination, not by tradition.

CARD 3

Choosing the d4 break

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. d3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. Nbd2 Re8 12. Nf1 Bf8 13. d4

Decision: After d4, which recapture preserves the better center and which file opens for each rook?

Memory: Break only when your pieces improve after the pawn exchanges.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
019 Decode: The compact c3-d3 shell	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
020 Play: The compact c3-d3 shell	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
021 Decode: Knight route d2-f1-g3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
022 Play: Knight route d2-f1-g3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
023 Decode: Choosing the d4 break	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
024 Play: Choosing the d4 break	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name both sides' strongest plans, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.